WHOSE GANDHI IS IT ANYWAY

A fight erupts over the control of two institutions representative of the Mahatma's legacy—the Sabarmati Ashram and the Gujarat Vidyapith. Can the interested parties rise above petty politics and work towards preserving all that Bapu stood for?

By JUMANA SHAH



ALAMY

Everyone wants a piece of Gandhi. Even those who think he was responsible for Partition and refuse to demonise the man who took his life cannot deny the place Bapu and his principles occupy in India's public consciousness. Hence the battle to claim the Mahatma's legacy or, more specifically, two institutions that are an inalienable part of him. The first is the Sabarmati Ashram—where Gandhi spent 13 years of his life, from 1917 to 1930—for which the Gujarat government has plans for an ambitious makeover. The other is the Gujarat Vidyapith, a university that the Mahatma founded in 1920, where controversy has erupted over appointments, to the top post as well as of the trustees. In Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-ruled Gujarat, both moves are being seen as attempts to appropriate Bapu and his inheritance.

First, the Sabarmati Ashram. A lasting memorial to his simple and austere way of life, the humble Gandhian abode is now slated for a 'world-class' makeover, for which Rs 1,200 crore has been earmarked. Among the proposals is one to expand the tourist area to 55 acres from the current five acres, restore the ashram to how it was when Gandhi lived there, redevelop 48 of the 65 original buildings, and create a 200-car parking space and a sprawling food court. While the state government maintains it will not tinker with the original ashram where Gandhi lived, several of these initiatives have upset the Gandhians, who fear that the redevelopment project will ruin the sanctity and simplicity of the Sabarmati Ashram and turn it into a 'Gandhi theme park'. The move, according to a statement issued by over 100 concerned citizens in 2021, "severely compromises and trivialises the sanctity of the present-day ashram". Among the opponents is also the Mahatma's great-grandson, Tushar Gandhi, who challenged the government's plans, only to have his plea rejected by the Gujarat High Court last year.